Course Topics

Strategic Analysis & Problem Solving

This note provides an indicative session-wise breakdown of the course, outlining the topics to be covered and mapping each session to a set of academic readings and practitioner insights. The readings, combined with problem-led classroom activities and faculty synthesis, are intended to blend theory, industry practice, and experiential learning. Across the course, students encounter the business problem first, construct an approach from first principles, and are then introduced to relevant frameworks and tools that can sharpen or extend their analysis.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the course, students should be able to:

- Frame an ambiguous business situation as a clear decision problem
- Decompose unfamiliar problems from first principles and identify the highest-value questions
- Form hypotheses and use quantitative and qualitative evidence to test them
- Evaluate alternative courses of action while making assumptions, trade-offs, and uncertainty explicit
- Develop recommendations that integrate commercial, operational, financial, and organisational considerations
- Translate a strategic recommendation into an executable plan
- Communicate a recommendation clearly and defend it when challenged
- Use AI intelligently in problem-solving while independently validating its outputs

Course Structure

An indicative session-wise overview of the course is given below:

Session	Topics Covered	Pre-Class Readings	Activities
1. From Ambiguity to a Decision	Problem definition; first-principles decomposition; hypotheses; root causes; prioritisation	- *Are You Solving the Right Problem?* (Harvard Business Review)	Ambiguous client brief - teams define the real decision problem and build their own structure *Frameworks: MECE/Value-Chain Mapping*
2. Understanding the Economics of a Business	Revenue and cost drivers; profitability; pricing; unit economics; value creation/destruction	- *A Quick Guide to Value-Based Pricing* (Harvard Business Review)	Diagnose a business with growing revenue but deteriorating profitability; request

		- Solving the *Pricing Puzzle in Inflationary* Times (BCG)	data and test competing hypotheses *Frameworks: Pricing, profitability trees*
3. Evaluating an Opportunity	Market sizing; customer demand; competitive dynamics; market attractiveness; economics of entry; right-to-win	- *Beating the Odds in Market Entry* (McKinsey Quarterly)	Assess whether a company should enter a new market or segment, including sizing and company-specific attractiveness *Frameworks: TAM/SAM/SOM*
4. Choosing How to Grow	Growth levers; business models; strategic prioritisation	- *The CEO's Guide to Growth* (BCG)	Generate competing growth paths for a company facing slowing growth and recommend a prioritised path
5. Strategic Choices Under Uncertainty	Build-buy-partner; M&A; due diligence; synergies; trade-offs	- *The Walt Disney Company and Pixar Inc.: To Acquire or Not to Acquire?* (HBS)	Evaluate strategic alternatives in the Disney-Pixar case and defend a recommendation against credible alternatives
6. From Decision to Execution	Execution planning; executive communication	- *Execution Is a People Problem, Not a Strategy Problem* (Harvard Business Review) - *Your Strategy Needs a Story* (BCG Henderson Institute) - *The Necessary Art of Persuasion* (Harvard Business Review)	Convert an earlier recommendation into a 90-day plan and defend it before a mock steering committee
7. The Decision-Maker's Perspective	Decision-making under uncertainty; organisational realities; working with advisors; judgement and influence	No prescribed reading; optional short briefing shared by guest speaker	CXO-led conversation around real strategic decisions, useful analysis, and why sound recommendations can fail
8. Integrated Business Challenge	Integrated problem framing, opportunity assessment, growth, strategic choices, and communication	Case packet	Teams receive different complex business cases without being told the problem type; they choose and defend their approach

9. Business Problem-Solving Lab I	Integrated problem solving; hypothesis testing; evidence gathering; recommendation development	Case packet	Ambiguous client brief plus incomplete information; teams structure the engagement and produce an initial client-ready deck
10. Business Problem-Solving Lab II + AI	Adapting hypotheses; new evidence; live defence; AI-assisted analysis; validation	Case packet	New information challenges the initial answer; teams revise and present to a simulated client, followed by an AI-use debrief

Assessment Structure

Assessment Component	Weight	Description
In-Class Individual Synthesis	20%	Short individual exercises at the end of selected sessions assessing problem framing, hypothesis formation, or concise recommendations
In-Class Team Submissions	25%	Short team outputs produced during problem-led sessions, assessing the application of analytical tools to unfamiliar business situations
Integrated Business Challenge	20%	Team analysis and presentation of an unfamiliar business problem without a prescribed framework, including justification of the approach selected
Final Business Problem-Solving Simulation	35%	Capstone assessment comprising the client-ready deck, final presentation, and live defence of the recommendation; individual questioning can be used to assess each student's reasoning